FREE PLAYBOOK · FINDING CUSTOMERS

Cold Email That Gets Replies

A plain-English guide for small business owners: who to write to, what to say in under 75 words, how to follow up without being a pest, and how to stay on the right side of UK rules.

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bemoreswan.com
Written for founders who do their own sales.

1 · THE PROBLEM

Why most cold emails get ignored

A stranger owes you nothing. Your email has a few seconds, on a phone, between two things they actually care about. Most cold emails waste those seconds in the same three ways.

They start with you

"We are a leading provider of…" The reader is thinking about their own business. An email that opens with yours reads as an advert, and adverts get deleted.

They are too long

Three paragraphs of features, a case study and a PS. Nobody reads a long email from someone they don't know. Short emails get read to the end.

They ask too much

"Can we book 30 minutes?" is a big ask from a stranger. It means diary space, a call and a sales pitch. Most people say no by saying nothing.

The fix in one sentence

Talk about **their** problem first, keep it **short**, and ask for something **small**: permission to send a useful resource, a free trial, or a one-word answer to a question.

> **THE RULE OF THUMB**
>
> If a busy owner can't read your email and reply "yes, go on" in under ten seconds, it's too long or it asks too much.

What "good" looks like

A good cold email feels like a note from someone who has noticed something true about the reader's business and has something genuinely useful to offer. It doesn't pretend to be a friend, it doesn't invent urgency, and it's easy to say no to. That's exactly why people say yes.

Cold email is a numbers game played with a small list. Twenty well-chosen businesses who get a thoughtful, short email will do more for you than two thousand who get a generic one, and they won't damage your reputation or your inbox.

2 · BEFORE YOU WRITE

Who, exactly?

Most bad cold emails are bad because the sender doesn't know who they're writing to. Fix that first.

Describe your ideal customer in one sentence

Fill this in. Be specific enough that you could find ten of them on Google this afternoon.

Question	Your answer
What kind of business?	
How big? (staff, sites, turnover)	
Where?	
What problem do they have that you solve?	
How would you know they have it? (a sign you could spot from outside)	

> **Example:** "Independent cafés in Greater Manchester with one or two sites, whose owners still do the books themselves. You can spot them because they post on Instagram about late nights doing the accounts."

Find the right person, not just the right company

- **In a small business, write to the owner.** Their name is usually on the website's About page, Companies House or LinkedIn.
- **Use a named address where you can.** A "hello@" inbox is read by whoever has time, and forwarded rarely.
- **Note one real detail** about each business: a recent post, a new branch, a job advert, a review. You'll use it in your opening line.

START SMALL

Build a list of 20. Write to five a day. You'll learn more from the first twenty replies (and silences) than from any template.

3 · THE ANATOMY

The five-part email, under 75 words

Every good cold email has the same bones. Four or five short paragraphs of one sentence each. Nothing else.

1. **Subject line.** Short, specific, honest. About them, not you. (More on this in chapter 6.)
2. **Their situation.** One sentence about something true of a business like theirs, ideally the real detail you noted. *"Running two cafés usually means the books get done after closing."*
3. **What you do. Optional, and only one line.** *"I help café owners hand that part over."* No claims you can't back up, no percentages you've made up.
4. **The offer.** Something small and genuinely useful: a guide, a trial, a quick answer. *"I've written a one-page checklist for getting café books ready for year end."*
5. **One question.** Easy to answer in a word. *"Mind if I send it over?"*

Do

- Use their name and one real detail
- Keep paragraphs to one sentence
- Write like you talk
- End on one question
- Sign off with your real name

Don't

- Put a link or attachment in the first email
- Ask for a call or a meeting
- Use "Re:" or "Fwd:" on a first email
- Invent urgency ("only 3 places left")
- Claim results you can't prove

Why no link? A link in a first email from someone the recipient has never heard of is one of the things spam filters look for, and it asks the reader to do something before they trust you. Asking "Mind if I send it over?" keeps the email clean and turns it into a conversation. The link goes in your reply, or in your first follow-up.

Three offers that make “yes” easy

The offer is the heart of the email. It should be worth having even if they never buy from you.

1 A free resource

A checklist, a short guide, a template, a price comparison. Something you can write once and send to everyone on your list. It shows you know your stuff before you ask for anything.

The ask: “Mind if I send it over?” or “Would it be useful if I sent it?”

Best when: your service needs trust before people buy, such as accountancy, consulting or design.

2 A free trial or first session

If people can try what you sell, let them. State it plainly and exactly: how long, whether a card is needed, what happens at the end. Never stretch the terms in the email.

The ask: “Would you like the link?”

Best when: the product sells itself once someone uses it, such as software, memberships or a first class.

3 Just a good question

No offer at all, just a genuine question about the problem you opened with. It works because it’s easy to answer and it starts a conversation on their terms.

The ask: “Is that something you’re dealing with at the moment?” or “Do you do that in-house or hand it over?”

Best when: you’re still learning what your customers care about, or the sale is a conversation anyway.

MAKE YOUR FREE RESOURCE IN AN AFTERNOON

- Write down the question customers ask you most often.
- Answer it as a one-page checklist or five short steps.
- Give it a plain title that names the result: “*The Year-End Checklist for Café Owners*”.
- Put it behind a simple sign-up form so people who want it can also choose to hear from you.

5 · TEMPLATES

Three emails you can adapt today

Written for an imaginary bookkeeper, Sam at Hollin Books, writing to independent cafés. Swap in your own business, and keep the shape.

Subject: Year-end books at Little Fern

Hi Priya,

Running two cafés usually means the books get done after closing, and year end lands at the worst time.

I've put together a one-page checklist for getting café books ready for your accountant.

Mind if I send it over?

Sam
Hollin Books

The free resource · 44 words · their situation first, one line of offer, one easy question.

Subject: Your second site

Hi Tom,

Congratulations on opening in Ancoats. A second site usually doubles the receipts and halves the time to sort them.

I do bookkeeping for independent cafés, and the first month is free, with nothing to sign.

Would you like the details?

Sam
Hollin Books

The free trial · 45 words · uses a real detail, states the terms plainly, asks permission before sending anything.

Subject: Quick question about your till

Hi Ellie,

Most café owners I speak to are still copying till reports into a spreadsheet each week.

Is that how you do it at the moment, or have you found something better?

Sam
Hollin Books

Just a question · 36 words · no pitch at all; the reply tells Sam whether there's a problem worth solving.

MAKE EACH ONE YOURS, IN TWO MINUTES

- **Swap in one real detail** about their business: a branch, a post, a review, a job advert.
- **Delete any sentence that would be true of every business.** If it could go to anyone, it says nothing.
- **Read it out loud.** If you wouldn't say it to them in person, rewrite it.
- **Count the words.** Over 75? Cut the line about you first.
- **Check the question.** Can they answer it in a word without looking anything up?

Writing to a business you already know a little?

Say how, in the first line: "We met at the Chamber breakfast in March" or "I buy my coffee from you on Fridays". A genuine connection beats any template. Never invent one.

6 · SUBJECT LINES

Subject lines that get opened

The subject line has one job: to look like an email from a real person about something relevant. Not like a newsletter, and not like a trick.

Good

- Year-end books at Little Fern
- Your second site
- Quick question about your till
- A checklist for café owners

Two to six words, specific, lower-key than you think.

Avoid

- "Re: our conversation" (there wasn't one)
- "URGENT: action needed"
- "Clarification needed on your account"
- "Transform your business today!!!"

Fake replies, invented accounts and urgency read as phishing, because that's what phishing does.

7 · FOLLOWING UP

Following up without being a pest

Most replies come after a follow-up, not the first email. People are busy, not uninterested. But every follow-up should be shorter and gentler than the last, and the sequence must end.

When	What it does	Example line
Day 3 Follow-up 1	Brings the email back to the top. If you offered a resource, include it now so they needn't reply to get it.	"In case it's easier, here's the checklist:" (then the link)
Day 10 Follow-up 2	A different angle: one useful tip, or a different reason it might matter.	"One thing on that checklist that catches most cafés out is…"
Day 17 The last one	Says it's the last. Leaves the door open. People often reply to this one.	"I won't keep emailing. If it's ever useful, just reply."

- **Stop the moment they reply,** whatever they say.
- **Stop if they sign up** for your resource or trial. They've said yes, so don't chase them.
- **Reply in the same thread** so they can see the history.
- **Three follow-ups at most.** After that it's pestering.

8 · WHEN THEY REPLY

When they reply

A reply is the whole point, so treat it like a customer walking through the door.

1. **Answer the same day.** Speed shows you're real and you care.
2. **Send exactly what you promised,** straight away. Don't make them ask twice.
3. **Answer their question before you ask yours.** If they ask about price, tell them.
4. **Suggest one small next step,** such as a short call, a quote or a trial, and make it easy to say no.
5. **If they say "not now",** thank them and ask if you may check back in a few months. Then actually do it.
6. **If they say "stop",** stop. Remove them, and don't email them again from another list.

9 · THE RULES

Staying legal in the UK

Cold email to businesses is allowed in the UK, with conditions. This is a plain-English summary of the key points, not legal advice. For the full picture, see the ICO's guidance on electronic mail marketing at **ico.org.uk**.

Limited companies and LLPs

Under PECR you can email staff at companies, LLPs and public bodies without their prior consent, as long as you say who you are and give a simple way to opt out.

Sole traders and some partnerships

These are treated like individuals. You generally need their consent before sending marketing email. Check before you add them to a cold list.

- [ ] Say clearly who you are and what business you're writing from.
- [ ] Include a working way to opt out in every email, and honour it promptly.
- [ ] Keep a list of people who've asked not to be contacted, and check it before every send.
- [ ] Only collect the business contact details you need, and have a reason you could explain (UK GDPR's "legitimate interests").
- [ ] If you also email people in the US or Canada, include your postal address. Their rules require it.
- [ ] Never buy lists of personal email addresses.

What to track

You don't need a dashboard. A spreadsheet with one row per business will do. Track three things, weekly.

Reply rate
Replies ÷ businesses emailed. The best single measure of whether your list and your message are right.

Good replies
Replies that say "yes" or ask a question. A low number here means the offer isn't right yet.

Opt-outs
If more than the odd person asks you to stop, you're writing to the wrong people. Fix the list, not the wording.

Change one thing at a time, such as the opening line, the offer or the subject, and send it to the next twenty. Keep what works.

Your checklist before you press Send

- [ ] I know exactly who this person is and one real thing about their business.
- [ ] The email opens with their situation, not with me.
- [ ] It's under 75 words, in four or five one-sentence paragraphs.
- [ ] There is no link and no attachment.
- [ ] I'm offering something small and useful, stated honestly.
- [ ] It ends with one question they can answer in a word.
- [ ] The subject line is short, specific and not a trick.
- [ ] I've said who I am, and there's a way to opt out.
- [ ] My follow-ups are booked: day 3 with the link, day 10, then a last one on day 17.
- [ ] They're not on my do-not-contact list.

Want the legwork done for you?

Be More Swan's Lead Generation Assistant finds businesses that fit your ideal customer, researches each one and drafts short, permission-based emails like the ones in this guide, along with the follow-ups.

Nothing is sent until you approve it.

See how it works at **bemoreswan.com**

